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Presidential Telephone Calls - Memorandum of Conversations 3/15/90 - 6/22/90

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MEMORANDUM OF TELEPHONE CONVERSATION

SUBJECT: Telephone Call to Chancellor Helmut Kohl of
the Federal Republic of Germany (U)

PARTICIPANTS: The President
Helmut Kohl, Chancellor
Robert Hutchings, NSC Staff (Notetaker)
Gisela Marcuse (Interpreter)

DATE, TIME June 3, 1990, 3:39 - 3:48 p.m.
AND PLACE: The Oval Office

The President: Helmut! How are you? (U)

Chancellor Kohl: Fine. How are you? (U)

The President: Good. We have had good meetings.... (U)

Chancellor Kohl: I saw the coverage on television. Everything
looked good; it left a good impression. (U)

The President: I'm delighted to hear that. There was a good
mood yesterday at Camp David. It was very relaxed, with a very
good ambience. We sat on the terrace and talked for hours. I
will be sending you a letter, probably tonight, on my meetings
with Gorbachev, but I wanted to fill you in on a couple of
specific points. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: One thing, George: I am most interested in how
he sees his position at home. (U)

The President: He seemed to radiate confidence. He didn't seem
concerned about Yeltsin. He tells me there will be a federation
meeting, at which he will have a discussion with Yeltsin and
others on the whole question of the union. Overall, despite his
problems, he seemed confident. A couple of points: Gorbachev
and I didn't return to the question of German unification, except
briefly, but it did come up in our press conference, which you
may have seen. (U)

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Chancellor Kohl: Yes, I saw it. (U)

The President: We left it there. You and I can talk about it next week, but I do want to read you one passage from my statement at the press conference. This is Bush speaking: "I stressed that the long held aspirations of the German people should be met without delay. On the matter of Germany's external alliances -- I believe -- as does Chancellor Kohl and the members of the Alliance -- that the united Germany should be a full member of NATO. President Gorbachev does not hold that view. But we are in full agreement that the matter of alliance membership is -- in accordance with the Helsinki Final Act -- a matter for the Germans to decide." That was in front of the whole world press, and Gorbachev didn't object when I read that last sentence. So the meeting would end up on a pleasant and upbeat note, I had sent my press statement, including that formulation, to Bessmertnykh the night before, and he came back before the press conference to say the Soviet side had no objections. We, of course, will have to see whether this reflects any flexibility on their part. (Ø)

In any event, we still have a lot of work to do. And I think a lot will depend on having a successful NATO Summit, which shows that the Alliance is changing in ways that can reduce the understandable concerns of the Soviet Union. So our NATO meeting takes on more importance. Lastly, he did raise the matter -- but only briefly -- of major Western economic assistance to the Soviet Union. I prefer not to talk about that on the open line, but I told him that I wanted to help. You and I can talk about this next week. So, that's where we stand. I'll send a letter and we can talk in more detail when we get together on June 8. (Ø)

Chancellor Kohl: Many thanks, and thanks especially for your kind support. (U)

The President: It's easy for me to do. We feel strongly about this, too. (U)

Chancellor Kohl: One request: I would like to have received your letter prior to 11:00 a.m. on Tuesday. My plane leaves for New York at noon. (U)

The President: Yes. I'll be sure you get that. I think we'll be getting it out tonight. (U)

-- End of Conversation --

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